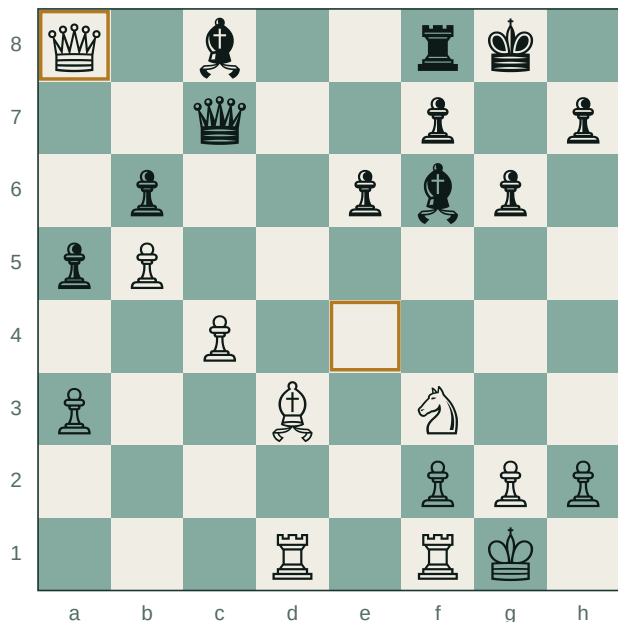


Clearance tactics: Black, move 20

Clearance tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 20.Qxa8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

20...Bb7 21. Qa7 Ra8 22. Qxa8+ Bxa8

20...Bb7 The bishop moves from c8 to b7. From b7 it attacks queen on a8 and knight on f3. Recorded reply: **21.Qa7**.

21...Ra8 The rook moves from f8 to a8. Recorded reply: **22.Qxa8+**.

22...Bxa8 The bishop captures the queen on a8.

At the end, nominal material is White 22 / Black 21 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +4:** the balance goes from -5 to -1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Opening a line helps only if your next move is timely. The defender may close the line or create a stronger threat.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A clearance move vacates a square or opens a line for another piece. The clearing piece may sacrifice itself to gain the time needed for the follow-up.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the rook, bishop, queen, or knight that needs access, then locate the friendly piece blocking its route or destination.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: queen on a8. Check for tactical protection.